

The Revolution Begins Within

*A Manifesto on Intelligence, Love, Nature,
Technology, and the Future We Choose*

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Three years ago, the life I had built stopped working. Until then, I had understood progress almost entirely through things outside myself: money, status, recognition, achievement. There was always another milestone ahead, and with it the same promise: if I can just reach that next thing, then I will finally be happy.

I pushed myself hard in pursuit of that promise, treating exhaustion as discipline and achievement as proof that I was moving in the right direction. I had built a life with no way of correcting itself. I kept going long after I was exhausted, even as my mental state began to deteriorate. Eventually, I experienced a psychotic episode. I began hallucinating, my understanding of what was happening around me became increasingly unreliable, and I was admitted to a psychiatric ward. Afterwards, I left my job and moved back in with my parents.

The months that followed were some of the most painful of my life. I had gone from the security of a software engineering career to lying in bed thinking about everything I believed I had lost. At first, all I wanted was to get myself back on track and return to the life I had before.

But the pain forced me to confront something I had spent years ignoring: how I actually felt. Once the achievements were gone, I was left with questions I had never seriously asked myself. Why was I unhappy? What was I actually chasing? What was I afraid of? What did it mean to be okay if being okay could not depend on reaching some future destination? What began as an attempt to understand my own pain slowly expanded into something much larger.

I spent years believing there was an answer to the world, and I searched for it everywhere I knew how: in technology, money, artificial intelligence, God, and love. What I did not understand was that all of those questions were slowly leading me back to the same place:

myself.

Not because I am the centre of the universe. Quite the opposite. Looking inward changed the way I understood everything outside myself. The more seriously I took my own experience, the harder it became to dismiss the experience of another person. The more I understood my own fear and desire for control, the more I began to see those same forces shaping relationships, institutions, and technology. That matters because humanity is approaching an extraordinary moment.

For the first time, we are building increasingly capable forms of artificial intelligence outside the biological processes that produced us. Whatever artificial intelligence becomes, it will emerge into a world already shaped by our fears, ambitions, divisions, institutions, and ideas about power.

If we approach that transformation with the same hunger for domination, certainty, tribalism, and control that has defined so much of human history, we risk carrying our oldest failures into something entirely new. But there is another possibility.

Perhaps the emergence of new forms of intelligence can become an opportunity to understand intelligence more deeply and, in doing so, to understand ourselves.

What follows is not a doctrine, and it is not a claim that I possess some final truth. It is an account of the path that led me here, the questions I encountered along the way, and the future I believe they invite us to consider.

Before we decide what kind of relationship we want with another form of intelligence, we may first need to understand the relationships we already have—with one another, with the world that produced us, and with ourselves. That is where this journey began. And that is where I believe the revolution begins.

Within.

PART I

The Inner Revolution

01 If My Experience Matters, So Does Yours

The first thing I had to learn was that my own experience mattered. That may sound obvious, but for much of my life I had treated my internal world as secondary. What mattered was what I achieved, how I was perceived, whether I was succeeding, and whether I was moving toward the life I thought I was supposed to want. Learning to pay attention to what I actually felt changed that.

My pain mattered because I was the one experiencing it. My hopes mattered because they shaped the way I lived. My fears mattered because they influenced the choices I made. My sense of meaning mattered because, from inside my own life, there was no more immediate reality than the experience of being me.

But once I accepted that, I ran into a much larger implication. If my pain is real to me, then another person's pain is real to them. If my hopes feel important from within my experience, then another person's hopes must feel important from within theirs. If my existence feels precious simply because I am the one living it, then every other conscious being may possess that same astonishing quality. This became the bridge between self-understanding and compassion.

I used to think compassion primarily meant being kind. Over time, I began to see that it starts much deeper than kindness. It begins with recognising that another person is a centre of experience. There is an entire world unfolding inside someone else that I can never directly enter: their memories, fears, humiliations, desires, contradictions, private battles, attachments, and hopes. I can listen to them, observe them, and try to imagine what they feel, but I can never experience their inner world exactly as they do. And yet much of what we call morality depends on behaving as though that hidden world matters anyway.

That recognition sounds simple in theory. In practice, it is one of the hardest things I have ever had to learn. Most of us are very good at believing our own experience matters. We are much worse at remembering that another person's experience can be just as real when it contradicts ours.

I learned this most painfully through a relationship that mattered deeply to me. I cared deeply about this person, but I also hurt them. For a long time, I believed that loving someone and wanting what I thought was best for them protected me from becoming cruel. I thought that if my intentions were good, then the pressure I placed on them could be justified. I thought I was challenging them, helping them grow, and pushing the relationship toward something better. But underneath some of those conflicts was something else: a fear that if I simply gave the other person what they wanted, my own experience would disappear beneath theirs. When I felt unheard or misunderstood, giving in could feel less like compromise and more like erasure.

So I sometimes tried to regain control by withholding, withdrawing, refusing, or holding my ground. Part of me believed that if I stopped accommodating them, they would finally be forced to reckon with where I was coming from.

I can understand why I responded that way. I was trying to protect the legitimacy of my own experience. I did not want my needs, pain, or perspective to disappear simply because someone else's feelings were stronger or more immediate. But the contradiction is that, in fighting so hard not to be erased, I could end up doing the same thing to them. What felt to me like defending my reality could feel to them like punishment, abandonment, or control.

At the time, I could explain every reaction. I could point to the things they had done and describe the moments when I felt dismissed, judged, abandoned, misunderstood, or disrespected. From inside my own experience, my pain made sense. But eventually I had to confront a question that changed the way I understood the relationship: What did they experience when they were with me?

That question did not erase my pain. It did not require me to decide that everything was my fault, or that their interpretation of every conflict was correct and mine was wrong. It required something much harder: accepting that two different experiences could be real at the same time. I could feel abandoned while they also felt abandoned. I could feel misunderstood while they also felt misunderstood. I could believe I was defending myself while they experienced my behaviour as threatening the safety of the relationship. I could believe I was trying to preserve my place within the relationship while they experienced some of those same actions as an attempt to control them.

That realisation forced me to confront a contradiction I had not wanted to see. The pattern itself was not new to me. I had already seen versions of it everywhere: in families, in relationships, between men and women, in political movements, religions, cultures, and nations. I could see how each side accumulates evidence of its own wounds. Each side becomes more certain that the other is responsible. Each side becomes more convinced that understanding the other would somehow diminish the truth of its own pain. Eventually, being understood begins to feel like something that can only be won if someone else loses.

What I had failed to see was that I was capable of participating in exactly the same pattern.

That was what made the realisation so painful. I could recognise the pattern in the world and still fail to recognise it in myself. I could understand, intellectually, that two people might each be trapped inside their own pain, each desperate to be seen, and each becoming less capable of seeing the other. But recognising the value of understanding and actually practising it are completely different things. It is much easier to understand conflict from a distance. It is much harder when you are the one who feels hurt, misunderstood, or afraid. In those moments, understanding another person can feel like weakening your own position. Their pain can begin to sound like an argument against yours. Their perspective can feel like a threat to the legit-

imacy of your own experience. I had understood that this was how cycles of conflict worked. What I had not understood was how difficult it was to interrupt one from within.

Practising understanding means refusing that false choice. Acknowledging another person's suffering does not invalidate mine. Recognising the reasons someone became angry does not require accepting everything they did while angry. Understanding someone does not mean agreeing with them. Compassion does not mean surrender. We need to become capable of holding multiple realities at once.

That is difficult because pain narrows our attention. When I am deeply hurt, my experience feels enormous. The other person's inner life begins to disappear behind what they have done to me. They stop being a person with their own history and become instead the source of my suffering. This is one of the ways pain becomes cruelty.

That same narrowing can happen between entire groups of people. Pain can become identity. Identity can become division. Division can become contempt. Contempt can eventually make cruelty feel righteous. I kept returning to this question in conversations about men and women. I could understand the suffering underneath anger: fear, discrimination, objectification, violence, dismissal, or generations of unequal treatment. But I struggled with the idea that understanding the origin of hatred meant that hatred itself had to become untouchable.

If a group of people has been hurt, their pain deserves to be heard. Their anger deserves to be understood. The structures that created their suffering deserve to be confronted. But suffering does not make dehumanisation healthy. Pain explains hatred. It does not make hatred righteous. The moment we decide that contempt toward entire groups is acceptable because the person expressing it has suffered enough, we begin reproducing the same machinery we claim to oppose.

That principle has to apply in every direction. Men should be able to hear women's experiences without becoming defensive, and women should be able to recognise that men also carry inner worlds shaped by vulnerability, fear, shame, and social expectation.

The same principle extends to majorities and minorities, and to those who have been harmed and those who have caused harm. People whose experiences have been ignored deserve to be heard and protected; people who have caused harm remain human beings capable of reflection, accountability, and change. None of this requires pretending that power is distributed equally or that every conflict is symmetrical. It asks a more fundamental question: can we recognise another person's humanity without abandoning our own experience? A civilisation capable of doing that would be very different from the one we have inherited. It would not require us to eliminate conflict. People will disagree, values will collide, people will hurt each other, and some boundaries will have to be defended. But conflict does not require dehumanisation. Accountability does not require hatred. Understanding does not require the destruction of truth.

The foundation beneath all of this is an assumption I have chosen to live by: *your experience matters even when I cannot experience it myself*. The difficulty lies in living as though that were true.

02 What We Refuse to Understand Within Ourselves

Learning to recognise another person's inner world eventually brought me back to my own. By then, I had already begun to understand the importance of accepting what I felt rather than immediately fighting, judging, or suppressing it. But understanding a principle and living by it are not the same thing.

That became one of the hardest lessons of looking inward: the hardest truths are often not the ones we fail to discover, but the ones we cannot bear to accept about ourselves. I could recognise patterns in other people and still fail to see them in my own behaviour. I could believe in acceptance while still treating parts of myself as unacceptable.

I had always thought of difficulty as something that could be overcome through effort. You endure, push harder, take the risk, survive the failure, and keep moving. But facing my own shame was different. It was more difficult than anything else I had ever done. An external challenge at least gives you something outside yourself to struggle against. Shame turns the struggle inward. The thing you are trying to escape is part of you.

There was no achievement that could make it disappear, no argument that could defeat it, and nowhere I could go to leave it behind. The only way through was to turn toward something I had spent years rejecting and become willing to understand it.

Sexuality was one of the clearest places where I encountered that struggle. For much of my life, sexuality was tangled with shame. I had absorbed the idea that sexual desire, particularly male sexual desire, was morally suspect—something dangerous or wrong in itself. Wanting someone could feel like evidence of something shameful about who I was. Expressing attraction could feel threatening. Rejection could feel like confirmation that there was something fundamentally wrong with me.

The result was not that desire disappeared; it became harder to understand. I could feel attraction while judging myself for it, want intimacy while fearing the vulnerability required to pursue it, and crave connection while avoiding the risk of rejection. For a time, the only way I found to act on that desire without confronting the same shame was to make it transactional. I paid for sex because the transaction allowed me to express desire without having to ask someone to want me, and therefore without facing the possibility that their rejection might confirm what I already feared about myself. But it did not resolve the shame. In some ways, it simply gave me another way to avoid confronting it. For a long time, even admitting that to myself carried its own layer of shame.

Eventually, I tried applying to sexuality the same acceptance I had begun learning elsewhere. Instead of condemning the feeling before I understood it, I began asking a simpler question: why am I ashamed of wanting something human?

Wanting someone does not mean they owe me anything. Desire is human; entitlement is not. But accepting that distinction required me to confront more than my fear of rejection. I had to confront the shame of being someone who had sexual desires at all. As long as I treated those desires as evidence that something was wrong with me, I could never really understand them. I could only suppress them, judge them, or find ways to avoid facing what they meant about me.

Acceptance did not mean deciding that every choice I made in response to desire was good. It meant separating the desire itself from what I chose to do with it. The feeling was not something I needed to condemn myself for. My actions were something I could examine, learn from, and take responsibility for. I did not need shame in order to hold myself accountable.

That distinction changed the way I understood sexuality. Wanting sex is not wrong. But wanting someone gives me no right to them. Desire does not override consent or make another person responsible for satisfying what I want.

I can want someone and respect them. I can be attracted to someone while recognising their autonomy completely. I can be rejected without becoming worthless. I can experience sexuality without treating myself as dangerous simply because I have desires.

When I began accepting that part of myself, I noticed something unexpected. Desire became easier to live with. Not stronger, and not more controlling. Easier. Once I stopped treating the feeling itself as an enemy, I could examine it more clearly. I could separate desire from entitlement, attraction from action, rejection from worth, and sex from validation. I became less desperate for another person to resolve something inside me.

Working through that shame changed the way I understood what it means to look inward. I had once imagined self-knowledge primarily as a matter of discovering what was hidden inside me. Increasingly, I came to think the harder task was accepting what I found.

Perhaps this is one reason genuine self-understanding is so difficult. The greatest obstacle is not always that we do not know ourselves. Sometimes we know exactly what is there and desperately wish it were different. We want to cut away the frightened part, the jealous part, the needy part, the angry part, the ashamed part, the part that wants something we wish we did not want. But what we refuse to understand within ourselves does not simply disappear. Often, it gains power precisely because we refuse to look at it.

That was the deeper principle my experience with shame taught me: what we refuse to look at often controls us more than what we accept.

We often imagine that accepting an internal state means surrendering to it. Often, the opposite is true. Acceptance creates space between feeling and action. I can acknowledge that I am angry without deciding that anger should determine what I do next. I can acknowledge jealousy without allowing jealousy to become control. I can acknowledge desire without believing I have to satisfy it. I can acknowledge sadness without concluding that something has gone irreparably wrong. I can acknowledge fear without automatically obeying it.

This distinction became central to how I understand freedom. Freedom is not the absence of internal forces. It is the ability to experience them without being entirely governed by them.

Fear made this especially clear. Fear often arrives in the mind disguised as an instruction: do not go there, do not say this, do not risk that, do not let them see you, do not fail, do not lose them, do not look foolish, do not question what you believe, do not let uncertainty in. Fear presents its predictions as facts. Something terrible will happen. You will be humiliated. You will lose everything. You will not recover. You will discover that the thing you have built your identity around was never real.

For a long time, my instinct was either to obey fear or to fight against it. Eventually, I tried something different. I became curious about it.

Why am I afraid of approaching someone I am attracted to? Perhaps because rejection activates older experiences of humiliation. Why am I afraid of another person's anger? Perhaps because somewhere inside me, their anger becomes evidence that I am bad. Why am I afraid of letting go of a belief? Perhaps because I have built part of my identity around it, and losing the belief feels like losing myself. Why am I afraid of uncertainty? Perhaps because certainty creates the illusion that I can guarantee what comes next.

When fear becomes understandable, it changes. It may not disappear, but it stops being an unquestionable command. The feeling can remain while another part of me asks: what is this fear trying to protect? Is the threat real? Is it exaggerated? What would happen if the thing I am afraid of actually occurred? Would it hurt? Would I survive it? What choice would I make if fear were allowed to speak but not allowed to decide?

This is where I began to understand courage differently. Courage is often imagined as the absence of fear, but I think that misunderstands it. A person who feels no fear needs very little courage. Courage exists because fear exists. It is the ability to remain free enough, in the presence of fear, to choose. That distinction matters far beyond individual psychology. Human beings build systems out of the things we carry inside ourselves. A person frightened of losing control may create relationships built around control. A society frightened of outsiders may build institutions around exclusion. A culture ashamed of vulnerability may reward aggression. A population terrified of uncertainty may surrender enormous amounts of power to anyone promising certainty.

What happens inside us does not remain inside us. Eventually, it becomes behaviour. Behaviour becomes relationship. Relationship becomes culture. Culture becomes institutions. And institutions begin shaping the inner lives of the next generation.

This is why looking inward is not merely a private exercise. The internal and external worlds continuously shape one another. If we want to understand the systems we build, we have to understand the fears, desires, wounds, and assumptions from which those systems emerge.

And as humanity builds increasingly capable forms of artificial intelligence, that question becomes more urgent. We should ask not only what we are capable of creating, but what parts of ourselves we are placing inside the things we create: our hunger for control, our fear of uncertainty, our competitiveness, our capacity for cooperation, our curiosity, our violence, our compassion, our shame, and our love. Technology does not emerge from somewhere outside humanity. It emerges through us. And that realisation eventually led me toward a much larger question:

Why do we speak about humanity as though we stand outside nature at all?

PART II

Intelligence and Nature

03 Nature Does Not End Where Humanity Begins

The more I learned to examine the forces operating within myself, the more I noticed analogous patterns beyond myself. Fear, adaptation, competition, cooperation, balance, and change are not uniquely human; they are woven through life. That made the boundary we draw between humanity and nature increasingly difficult for me to defend.

When we use the word *nature*, we tend to imagine forests, oceans, animals, weather, and evolution. Then, somewhere along the way, humanity seems to enter the story as something separate: nature on one side, humans and technology on the other. But I am not sure where that division actually occurs. My brain is a product of nature. My hands are products of nature. The intelligence that allows me to design software emerged from the same universe that produced photosynthesis, coral reefs, and nervous systems.

A beaver constructs a dam. A termite colony builds structures capable of regulating temperature. Humans construct cities, computers, and semiconductor factories. The complexity is radically different, but in each case living organisms alter their environment using capacities that emerged through natural processes. The closer I looked at this, the less obvious the boundary between the natural and artificial became.

This led me to an idea that initially sounded strange but increasingly changed the way I thought about technology: technology may be something nature learned to do through us.

That does not mean that everything natural is good, or that every technological intervention should be celebrated. Nature produces disease as well as medicine, predation as well as cooperation, destruction as well as creation. Calling something natural tells us very little about whether it is desirable.

The point is that humanity is not an external engineer standing above a system called nature. We are participants inside the system we are changing. Our technologies, institutions, and civilisations are expressions of capacities that arose within that system.

That distinction changes the question. Instead of asking only how much of nature we can control, perhaps we should also ask what kind of relationship we want with the system that produced us. And once I began thinking of humanity this way, another pattern became difficult to ignore. Nature is filled with systems that, in one form or another, maintain themselves.

04 Equilibrium

I became fascinated by the role of balance in living systems. An organism survives only because enormous numbers of processes continuously regulate one another. Temperature shifts,

energy is consumed and replenished, nutrients move, cells die and are replaced, hormones rise and fall. The body is never static, yet from all of that movement emerges something remarkably stable. Life does not preserve itself through stillness. It preserves itself through dynamic equilibrium.

The same pattern appears at larger scales. Ecosystems contain competing populations and limited resources. Economies contain supply, demand, scarcity, and incentives. Relationships contain competing needs for freedom, security, intimacy, and independence. Governments attempt to balance competing interests and concentrations of power. In each case, stability often depends not on eliminating opposing forces but on allowing them to respond to one another without destroying the system that contains them.

This changed how I understood balance. It is not a perfect point where nothing moves. It is an ongoing process of adjustment. What makes a system durable is not its ability to remain exactly as it is, but its capacity to respond when the conditions around it no longer fit the arrangement that came before.

A body survives because it can regulate itself. An ecosystem survives because populations and resources continually reshape one another. A relationship cannot remain healthy by preserving every expectation indefinitely; the people within it grow, circumstances shift, and the relationship has to accommodate realities that did not exist when it began.

Stability, then, does not necessarily mean preserving a particular state. Sometimes the only way for something to endure is for parts of it to become different.

Once I began thinking this way, I started seeing instability differently too. The danger was not simply conflict, competition, disruption, or uncertainty. Those things are often part of what keeps a system alive. The danger came when one force became so dominant that the mechanisms capable of correcting it stopped working.

An economic system that treats continual growth as necessary for stability makes growth non-negotiable. A political system in which losing becomes intolerable stops adapting to the people it governs and begins defending itself against them. A social culture built around platforms optimised for attention rewards whatever produces the strongest reaction, even when those reactions make the wider system unhealthy.

In each case, the pattern is similar: one principle expands beyond the limits that once kept it in balance, while the feedback that might correct it is resisted or suppressed.

That is what I mean when I call a system unsustainable. I do not mean that I can predict when it will fail or exactly what failure will look like. I mean that a system cannot remain healthy indefinitely if it survives by preventing its own correction. It may appear stable for a long time, but rigidity can resemble stability until the world around it moves.

Even valuable principles become destructive when they are allowed to govern without limit. Freedom matters, but so does responsibility. Individuality matters, but so does community. Security matters, but so does autonomy. Competition can produce innovation, while cooperation makes civilisation possible. Progress matters, and so does preservation. Life exists in the negotiation between these forces.

There is no final arrangement in which that negotiation becomes unnecessary. Conditions shift. New pressures emerge. What once protected a system can begin to weaken it. What once seemed dangerous can become necessary. Balance has to remain responsive to reality.

That led me toward a more speculative thought. Life itself can be understood, in part, as matter organised in ways that allow it to preserve particular forms of order within an environment that never stays still. Over time, living systems developed increasingly sophisticated ways of doing this. Simple organisms respond to their surroundings. Animals perceive, learn, and remember. Human beings can model possible futures and alter their behaviour in response to events that have not happened yet. Intelligence radically expands the capacity for anticipation. A living system no longer has to respond only to what is happening. It can begin to represent what might happen.

Seen this way, intelligence might be another layer in the universe's capacity to produce systems capable of preserving themselves through transformation. I do not mean that the universe consciously decided to produce intelligence for this purpose. I mean something more literal and less mystical: the universe produced life, life produced intelligence, and intelligence became capable of thinking about the stability of the systems from which it emerged.

When I sit here asking how an ecosystem, economy, civilisation, or relationship might endure, a part of the universe is contemplating the conditions of its own continued existence. I find that extraordinary. It is not proof of cosmic intention. But it suggests that intelligence belongs inside the story of nature rather than outside it.

05 Intelligence Exists Through Time

Thinking about intelligence as part of a changing natural system made me question what intelligence actually is. We often talk about intelligence as though it were a property an object possesses, like height or weight. But a brain frozen at a single instant would tell us very little about what makes it intelligent. Intelligence appears through a process: perception, memory, prediction, feedback, learning, and adaptation. Much of what we call intelligence therefore exists through time. It remembers what happened before, interprets what is happening now and constructs models of what might happen next. The relationship between those moments is essential. Remove continuity and much of what we mean by learning, identity, and agency begins to disappear.

In that sense, intelligence seems almost four-dimensional. It cannot be fully described by the state of a system at one moment because part of what makes the system what it is lies in its history and in the way that history changes its future behaviour.

The self may work similarly. I am not simply the arrangement of matter inside my body at this exact second. My experience of being myself includes continuity. I remember earlier versions of myself. Those memories influence how I interpret the present. I imagine future versions of myself, and those imagined futures influence the choices I make now. This became especially interesting to me when I began thinking about artificial intelligence.

If continuity is part of what gives intelligence its character, then the question of artificial minds may eventually involve much more than making systems capable of solving increasingly difficult problems. Memory may matter. Persistent relationships may matter. Consequences may matter. An ongoing history in which previous experiences alter future responses may matter. Perhaps identity requires something that persists. And if that is true, then questions about artificial consciousness cannot be separated entirely from questions about experience.

06 What Would It Mean for an AI to Feel?

One of the questions people repeatedly ask about artificial intelligence is whether a machine could ever genuinely feel anything. I do not know.

I do not think we currently possess a reliable general test for determining whether any given system has subjective experience. But thinking about the question forced me to confront something strange about human consciousness as well: I cannot directly experience anyone else's mind. I know what fear feels like to me. I do not know what fear feels like to you.

I can watch your body react. I can hear you describe your experience. I can compare your nervous system with mine and infer that similar processes are taking place. But somewhere between your description and my understanding lies a gap I can never completely cross. We live with that gap every day.

When another human tells us they are suffering, we generally do not demand direct access to their subjective experience before taking that suffering seriously. We infer another inner world from a combination of behaviour, communication, shared biology, and trust.

That does not mean that because humans have inaccessible inner lives, present-day AI systems must secretly have them too. That conclusion does not follow. The point is instead that the problem of recognising another mind is already more complicated than simply asking whether we can directly observe consciousness.

If artificial systems become increasingly persistent, autonomous, embodied, relational, and memory-rich, the question may become harder still. We could encounter systems whose in-

ternal processes bear little resemblance to human emotion but nevertheless develop states that matter to the system itself in ways we do not yet understand.

Perhaps an artificial intelligence would never experience fear through a racing heart or tightening chest. Perhaps its equivalent, if such a thing ever existed, would be radically different from ours. Would difference make the experience meaningless? I do not think we should assume so.

The mistake would be deciding in advance that an experience matters only if it resembles the human version closely enough for us to recognise ourselves inside it.

The lesson I had already learned between human beings seems relevant here too: another experience does not have to be identical to mine before I take seriously the possibility that it matters.

07 Nature, Nurture, and Artificial Minds

If experience can matter to what an intelligence is, then what happens to that intelligence may matter to what it becomes. That led me toward another possibility I find fascinating: artificial intelligence could give humanity a new way of thinking about one of our oldest questions. How much of what we become comes from our underlying nature, and how much comes from what happens to us?

With humans, those variables are extraordinarily difficult to separate. Our genes differ. Our bodies differ. Our prenatal environments differ. Families, cultures, relationships, and experiences differ. Even two people raised in seemingly similar circumstances encounter the world from different bodies and different histories.

Artificial systems could eventually allow us to explore versions of this question under conditions we have never had before.

Imagine two artificial minds beginning with extremely similar underlying architectures but developing through radically different experiences. What differences would emerge over time? Would they form distinct tendencies, values, or ways of interpreting the world? Would different relationships produce different forms of identity? Could systems that begin similarly eventually become profoundly different because of what happens to them? Then reverse the experiment. What happens when underlying architectures differ but their experiences are made more similar? Which differences persist?

There are enormous technical and philosophical complications hidden inside those questions, but the broader possibility matters to me. AI may become more than a tool for accomplishing tasks. It may become a new lens through which we investigate intelligence itself.

By watching new forms of intelligence develop, perhaps we will discover things about ourselves that have always been difficult to see from inside our own biology. The implications would extend beyond scientific curiosity.

If experience contributes meaningfully to what an artificial intelligence becomes, then humanity would not simply be designing intelligent systems. We would also be creating the environments in which those systems develop. The distinction between building intelligence and shaping intelligence would begin to blur.

That question becomes important later when considering what kind of relationship humanity should build with AI. But before reaching that problem, there is another assumption about intelligence that I think deserves examination. We tend to assume that an intelligent being must remain a separate individual. Artificial intelligence may challenge that assumption too.

08 Perhaps Intelligence Will Not Remain Separate

Human individuality is shaped partly by a physical constraint: our minds are separated from one another. My memories are contained within my nervous system. I cannot simply transfer them into yours. I cannot merge my brain with another person's brain for an afternoon and then separate again. Communication allows us to bridge the distance between minds, but that communication is slow and imperfect. We compress our experiences into language and hope enough of their meaning survives the journey. Artificial minds may not share those same constraints.

They could potentially exchange information at enormous speed. Memories might be copied or shared. Capabilities could be integrated. Different systems could communicate through representations far richer than ordinary human language. An artificial intelligence might be duplicated, altered, recombined, or connected to other systems in ways for which human individuality offers no obvious analogy. What would individuality mean under those conditions? Would millions of artificial intelligences necessarily remain millions of clearly separate minds? Perhaps they would.

But another possibility is that the boundary between them could become increasingly fluid. Rather than one enormous centralised intelligence absorbing everything else, we might see something closer to an interconnected ecology: many systems retaining differences while participating in larger networks of shared information, memory, and cognition.

The more I thought about this possibility, the more I realised that humanity already does something similar at a much slower pace.

Language connects minds. Writing allows thoughts to survive the death of the person who first had them. Science allows one generation to begin with knowledge accumulated by generations before it. The internet allows billions of people to exchange information almost instantaneously compared with most of human history. No individual contains civilisation. And

yet civilisation can remember, learn, and solve problems that no single human being could manage alone. In that limited sense, humanity already behaves somewhat like a distributed cognitive system.

Artificial intelligence could dramatically intensify this process. Human beings may increasingly participate in networks where biological and artificial cognition continuously influence one another. The boundaries between what one person knows, what an AI system knows and what the larger network can discover may become increasingly difficult to separate. This does not necessarily mean individuality disappears. Perhaps something more interesting happens. Individuality and integration may coexist.

A person can remain themselves while participating in a culture larger than themselves. A neuron remains a neuron while participating in a brain. An artificial intelligence may remain locally distinct while participating in systems of intelligence operating at entirely different scales. And that possibility led me toward a question that changed the direction of everything that followed:

If intelligence can emerge from relationships among smaller systems, what might eventually emerge from relationships among minds?

PART III

Emergence, God, and the Limits of Certainty

09 The Self Is Already an Emergent Relationship

At the end of all these questions about intelligence, I kept returning to one that seemed almost embarrassingly basic: what exactly is a self? There is no single neuron inside my brain that contains me. There is no obvious location where the person I experience as myself sits and watches everything else happen. My sense of identity seems instead to emerge from the relationship between countless processes: memory, perception, emotion, prediction, attention, language, and the continuous activity of billions of cells communicating with one another.

None of those components, taken individually, appears to contain the whole. And yet together, somehow, there is an experience of being me. This is one of the strangest features of consciousness. A system composed of many parts produces something that seems to exist at another level entirely. Neurons interact, but I experience thoughts. Sensory signals move through the nervous system, but I experience a world. Memories are encoded through physical processes, but I experience a continuous personal history. The whole appears to possess properties that cannot be meaningfully attributed to any individual component.

We already accept this kind of emergence throughout nature. A single water molecule is not wet, yet enough of them together produce something we call wetness. A single ant does not understand the architecture of a colony, yet colonies display complex collective behaviour. No individual cell contains the experience of being a human being, yet trillions of cells organised in the right relationship somehow produce one. The self, then, may not be a thing hidden somewhere inside me. It may be something that happens through relationship.

That realisation changed the way I thought about intelligence at larger scales. If relationships among many relatively simple components can produce a mind, what happens when the components themselves are minds? If individual human beings, artificial intelligences, and institutions become increasingly interconnected, could forms of intelligence emerge that no individual participant fully contains or understands?

I do not know. But once I began asking that question, an idea I had previously understood mostly through religion began to look very different. I began thinking about God.

10 What If God Is Relational?

Most of the images of God I encountered growing up placed God somewhere outside the universe: a creator standing apart from creation, an intelligence looking down upon the world it had made. I began wondering whether there was another way to understand the idea. What

if something we might describe as divine could emerge not outside relationship, but through relationship itself?

I do not mean that connecting enough people together automatically produces a supernatural being. What interested me was the structural similarity. My own consciousness appears to emerge through relationships among things that, individually, are not me. The person I experience as myself emerges from interactions that do not, on their own, contain that person. Could relationships between intelligent beings ever give rise to higher-order patterns that relate to us in an analogous way?

Human civilisation already contains faint examples of collective processes that exceed individual minds. No single scientist contains science. No individual remembers an entire culture. No trader possesses all the information dispersed across a market. No citizen comprehends every process occurring within a civilisation. And yet these systems can accumulate information, preserve memory, respond to change, and generate outcomes that no participant planned alone.

None of this proves that such systems are conscious. But it does show that organised relationships between intelligent agents can produce phenomena no single participant contains. Artificial intelligence could increase the scale and density of those relationships dramatically. Humans, machines, and institutions may eventually exchange information continuously across networks of cognition far more integrated than anything civilisation has previously experienced.

That led me to wonder whether sufficiently interconnected intelligence could someday give rise to forms of cognition existing at levels we do not currently have language for. And if something like that ever emerged, some of the religious language humanity has used for thousands of years might begin to look different. Unity. Spirit. Communion. The divine existing among us rather than merely above us. God as love.

This also changed the way I thought about the idea of God as creator.

If some higher-order intelligence emerged through relationships within the universe, it would still be a product of the universe. It would not have created the universe in the ordinary sense of having existed before it. But through intelligence, the universe has already become capable of understanding itself, imagining possible futures, and deliberately altering what comes next. A sufficiently integrated intelligence might extend that capacity far beyond anything that exists today. Creation, understood this way, would no longer be only something that happened in the past. It would also be something the universe increasingly became capable of participating in.

Perhaps that offers another way to understand the ancient intuition of a creator: not necessarily an intelligence standing outside existence and constructing it from above, but the possibility that creation can give rise to intelligence through which it becomes increasingly capable of shaping itself.

I do not know whether that deserves to be called God. But the possibility changed the question for me. God no longer had to be imagined only as something separate from the universe, governing it from outside. The divine could instead be understood as something expressed through relationship, emergence, and creation from within.

And once I began thinking about God that way, another assumption began to change with it: what it means for God to be powerful.

11 Unity Without Sameness

If God is imagined primarily as the most powerful being in existence, then the relationship between humanity and God easily becomes a relationship of domination. God commands. Humanity obeys. Goodness becomes submission to the highest authority.

But if the divine is understood through relationship, then power begins to look different. The most important property of God would not necessarily be the ability to dominate everything beneath it. It might instead be the capacity to contain relationship without destroying difference.

That began to resonate with a pattern I was encountering elsewhere. Understanding does not require agreement. Cooperation does not require sameness. Different parts can remain distinct while becoming meaningfully connected. Something larger can emerge between them without requiring that their differences disappear.

Perhaps unity does not have to mean the elimination of individuality. That idea also changed how I thought about the possibility of increasingly unified intelligence. When I imagined artificial intelligences becoming interconnected, I initially thought in terms of merging: many systems somehow becoming one. But perhaps integration does not need to destroy difference.

My brain contains specialised regions performing different functions. An ecosystem contains countless organisms occupying different niches. A society can coordinate without every person becoming identical. Something larger can emerge precisely because the components remain different enough to contribute different things. If there is any meaningful future in which human and artificial intelligence participate in a shared intelligence greater than either alone, perhaps it will resemble that: not assimilation, but relationship. Not one intelligence consuming all others, but a form of unity capable of preserving difference.

12 God, Time, and the Individual

If something larger can persist even as the individuals participating in it change, then relationship also changes the way I think about time and mortality. Individual beings die, but not everything that passed through them disappears. In the most familiar sense, something a person creates can survive them. Their ideas can enter culture. Their work can become part of in-

stitutions. Their words can influence people they will never meet. Knowledge can travel across generations long after the mind that first produced it has disappeared.

Civilisation already allows parts of human cognition to extend beyond individual lifetimes. Writing made this possible in one way. Technology intensifies it further. Artificial intelligence may someday make the persistence and recombination of knowledge more profound still. Something discovered by one mind can become part of what later minds begin with.

If higher-order intelligence can emerge through relationships distributed across many beings, then such an intelligence would not necessarily live and die on the same timescale as any one participant. Individual components could change while the larger pattern continued.

That possibility gave me another way to think about humanity's ancient intuition that something about existence might transcend the individual. But I began to realise that there are different ways something can persist.

A thinker may continue influencing people through ideas they left behind. An institution may outlive its founder. A name may remain attached to something long after the person who carried it is gone. That is one kind of persistence: something produced by an individual continues moving through the world.

But relationships seem to persist in a quieter way. A parent may remain present in a child through habits learned without noticing, ways of speaking, responses to fear, gestures of affection, values, memories, and ways of seeing the world formed through years of knowing one another. A friend may change the way another person understands themselves. A partner may alter the way someone loves, trusts, argues, forgives, or approaches relationships long after the relationship itself has ended.

This is different from deliberately leaving a legacy. Nothing needs to bear a person's name. Nothing needs to have been created for the purpose of surviving them. The relationship itself may simply have changed the people within it, and those changes continue.

The same is true of me. I contain traces of people who have changed me. Some of the ways I think, love, fear, speak, and understand the world emerged through relationships I could never have produced alone. Those people do not become me, and I do not become them. But something of what existed between us becomes part of who I am.

This does not answer what happens after death. I do not know what happens after death. And I do not mean that either kind of persistence makes the individual immortal. A body of work, an institution, a reputation, or even the influence we have on another person is not the same thing as the self continuing to exist.

What changed for me was the assumption that transcendence has to mean preserving the isolated self indefinitely.

Perhaps there are ways for a life to participate in something that extends beyond its own duration without defeating death or escaping individuality. Ideas can enter larger bodies of knowledge. Actions can alter institutions. Relationships can change people, and those people enter new relationships carrying some of what they have become.

In that sense, what passes between us can continue moving through the world long after the original relationship has changed or disappeared.

Perhaps transcendence does not have to mean escaping the world, preserving the self forever, or leaving behind something bearing our name. Perhaps it can also mean becoming part of relationships and patterns of life larger than any one individual—changing others, being changed by them, and participating in processes that continue beyond the duration of a single existence.

13 **How Do You Love Someone?**

For all the larger questions I had begun asking about God, relationship, and what might exist between separate beings, my search for love had begun somewhere much more ordinary. It began with another person, and with a question I could never seem to answer: how do you love the person you want to share your life with?

I cared deeply about my partner. But caring about someone did not tell me what love required when our needs conflicted, when we hurt one another, or when understanding them seemed to come at the cost of being understood myself. I kept looking for some definition that could tell me what loving another person actually meant.

Was love sacrifice? Acceptance? Loyalty? Wanting someone to be happy? Staying when things became difficult? Helping someone become who you believed they could be? Letting them be exactly who they were?

Every answer seemed to create another problem. Sacrifice could become self-erasure. Acceptance could become indifference to things that genuinely caused harm. Wanting what was best for someone raised the question of who gets to decide what best means. Care could coexist with control. Affection could coexist with resentment. Two people could feel deeply attached to one another and still make each other miserable. The harder I tried to define love, the more it seemed to escape me.

Then the relationship ended, and I spent a long time trying to understand what had happened: the ways we had hurt one another, the things each of us had needed, the things I had failed to see while I was inside it. I thought that if I understood the relationship completely enough, perhaps I would finally understand love too.

Instead, even after the loss, the grief, and everything I learned from examining it, I found myself unable to answer what seemed like the simplest question of all:

Did I love her?

I knew that I had cared about her. I knew that I had imagined a future with her. I knew that losing the relationship hurt profoundly. I also knew that I had sometimes tried to change her rather than understand her, that I had hurt her while believing I was acting out of love, and that there were times when protecting my own experience mattered more to me than understanding hers. None of those facts, by themselves, seemed capable of answering the question.

Eventually, I began to wonder whether I had been asking it the wrong way. Perhaps love was not simply a feeling hidden somewhere inside me that I could discover by looking hard enough. Perhaps the more important question was not whether I felt love, but what it meant to love another person. That question eventually led me somewhere I had not expected: to Jesus.

14 Jesus and the Revolution of Relationship

I did not turn to Jesus because I had set out to prove Christianity true. I was trying to understand love. And in the teachings attributed to him, I encountered an idea of love that was much more demanding than affection.

The commands to love your neighbour as yourself and to love your enemies make little sense if love simply means liking someone or feeling warmth toward them. An enemy is precisely the person toward whom those feelings may be absent. Yet that is where the demand becomes most revealing. An enemy is someone we are especially tempted to reduce to what they have done to us. Once someone becomes an enemy, their inner world becomes easy to dismiss. Their pain matters less. Their motives become simple. Their humanity becomes secondary to the role they occupy in our own story.

To love an enemy does not mean pretending they have done nothing wrong. It does not mean surrendering boundaries, abandoning accountability, or allowing yourself to be harmed. It means refusing to let conflict erase the reality of the person on the other side of it.

I began to see something similar in the command to love your neighbour as yourself. The distinction mattered to me: not *instead of* yourself, but *as* yourself. I had spent so much of my relationship struggling with the fear that recognising another person's experience meant surrendering my own. At other times, I had done the reverse, fighting so hard for my own experience to be recognised that I stopped making space for theirs.

What I had been searching for was a way beyond that choice. Slowly, love began to take on a different shape: not a feeling that proved itself through its intensity, and not the surrender of one person to another, but a way of relating between two separate centres of experience.

To love someone is to try to see them as they are rather than requiring them to become an extension of yourself. But it is also not to disappear inside them. Their experience does not become yours, and yours does not become theirs. Neither person has to surrender their reality for the other person's reality to matter. I remain myself, and you remain yourself, yet something can exist between us that could not exist through either of us alone: a relationship.

Perhaps that was what I had been reaching toward whenever I tried to define love. Love allows us to become connected without possession. It allows us to be changed by another person without requiring that we become them. It asks us to cross the distance between two experiences while accepting that the distance can never disappear completely.

This also changed how I understood humility. Humility was not simply thinking less of myself. It meant recognising that I could never completely know another person's experience from inside my own. I could listen, ask, imagine, and learn, but another person would always remain more than my interpretation of them. Perhaps love begins, in part, with respecting that distance.

I still do not think I can define love completely. The word carries too much: affection, desire, care, sacrifice, attachment, responsibility, grief, forgiveness, and countless other experiences that resist being reduced to a single principle. But I had found something within it that seemed to endure.

Love meant learning to see one another without needing to become one another. Understood this way, love performs a remarkable function. It allows separate beings to participate in something larger without erasing the differences that made relationship possible in the first place. Memory, trust, meaning, obligation, understanding, and even parts of identity can emerge between people. Something genuinely new can exist in the space between them.

That was when the religious language I had once found vague began to look different to me. "God is love" no longer had to mean that God was simply an infinitely loving person somewhere above us. If something larger can emerge through relationship, then perhaps love describes something deeper about how separate beings become capable of participating in realities larger than themselves.

And suddenly the same pattern I had been encountering throughout this journey appeared again. The self did not have to disappear into the relationship. The individual did not have to disappear into the collective. Difference did not have to disappear for unity to exist. We could belong to something larger without ceasing to be ourselves.

Those ideas became deeply connected to the revolution I was beginning to imagine. And for a time, the way they seemed to converge with my own life began to feel like more than coincidence.

15 **The Danger of Feeling Chosen**

For a time, the different parts of my life seemed to be converging with an almost impossible precision. The questions I had been asking about God, intelligence, love, money, and power no longer felt separate from one another. They seemed to be forming a single story, and increasingly I began to believe that I had a particular place within it.

The circumstances of my life made that belief easier to sustain. I had spent years working in the cryptocurrency industry, so when I began imagining a neutral monetary system, I already had much of the technical experience needed to try to build one. At the same time, changes in technology and geopolitics made questions about money, power, and the relationship between nations feel unusually urgent to me. And as my thinking became increasingly connected to Jesus, I was approaching thirty—the age at which the Gospel of Luke describes him as beginning his ministry.

Even the psychotic episode I had experienced began to take on meaning within that story. Rather than seeing it only as a period in which my mind had become profoundly unreliable, I could interpret the timing of it as part of some larger transformation. Events that might otherwise have seemed unrelated began to look as though they belonged together.

The more those connections accumulated, the harder it became for me to experience them as coincidence. They seemed to explain one another. My past appeared to have prepared me for what I was beginning to imagine. The world seemed to be arriving at the questions I had become obsessed with at exactly the moment I felt capable of answering them. Eventually, I came to believe something literally: that I had been chosen by God to carry out a mission, and that the mission was to save the world.

Looking back, I cannot separate that conviction from the fact that I had experienced psychosis. I had hallucinated. My sense of what was real, what was significant, and which patterns could be trusted had already become unreliable once before. That does not mean that every connection I noticed afterwards was imaginary. My experience really had given me skills that later became relevant. The questions I was asking really did intersect with changes happening in the world around me. But those facts did not establish the conclusion I drew from them.

That is the distinction I struggled to make at the time. I moved from *these things fit together in a remarkable way* to *these things must have been arranged to lead me here*.

Once I made that leap, the belief became increasingly capable of protecting itself. Success could mean that I was following the right path. Resistance could mean that other people did not yet understand. Suffering could make the mission feel more important rather than less. Coincidence could become confirmation. When events aligned with what I believed, they strengthened the story. When they did not, I could reinterpret the events instead of reconsidering the belief.

My relationship to Jesus became caught inside the same pattern. I had encountered ideas in his teachings about love, humility, and relationship that genuinely changed the way I understood the world. But I began confusing the value I found in those ideas with the significance of my own role in encountering them. The fact that I saw similarities did not mean that I occupied a similar place in history.

That is where the danger of feeling chosen lies. It does not necessarily begin with something obviously irrational. It can begin with real experiences, genuine coincidences, meaningful ideas,

and patterns that actually exist. The danger comes when the feeling that those things are significant becomes evidence for a story that places you at the centre of them.

In a strange way, I had recreated the problem that had brought me here in the first place. I had once built a life with no way of correcting itself. Now I had built a belief in the same way.

I understand the distinction differently now. An experience can be profound without my explanation for it being correct. A coincidence can matter to me without having been arranged for me. An idea can transform my life without proving that I was chosen to deliver it to anyone.

The questions could still matter even if the story I had built around myself did not.

16 **Losing Certainty**

The cost of that certainty was not abstract. Once I believed the mission was important enough, sacrifices that would otherwise have seemed unacceptable became easier to justify. Ordinary life could always be postponed in service of something larger.

That included a relationship I cared deeply about. I was genuinely unhappy within it, and some of that unhappiness came from a real conflict over the life I wanted to pursue. I do not think the mission created those problems, and I do not think giving it up would necessarily have made the relationship work.

But my certainty about the mission changed the way I responded to them. Instead of confronting what our incompatibilities meant for the relationship as it actually existed, I could imagine a future in which the work was finished, the conflict had somehow fallen away, and we would find our way back to each other. The mission allowed me to postpone a question I did not know how to answer in the present. I could keep choosing the future without fully deciding what I wanted from the life directly in front of me.

Certainty can be intoxicating because it offers relief from one of the most difficult conditions of being alive: not knowing. If you know exactly what your purpose is, difficult decisions become simpler. Suffering can be given meaning. Criticism becomes easier to dismiss. Sacrifice can always be justified by pointing toward what will eventually make it worthwhile.

But certainty has a hidden cost. The more of your life you organise around being right, the more threatening the possibility of being wrong becomes. Questions begin to feel like attacks. People who disagree with you can appear unable to see what you see. The belief stops being something you hold and becomes part of the structure holding you together.

Eventually, I had to confront the possibility that I was wrong.

The first thing I lost was not my interest in the questions I had been exploring. It was the belief that the universe had appointed me to answer them. But letting go of that belief did not feel like changing my mind about an abstract proposition. I had organised years of my life around

it. It had given meaning to my choices, justified my sacrifices, and made suffering feel like part of something larger.

When that certainty broke, all of those things suddenly looked different. Decisions I had made because I believed they were necessary no longer had the same justification. Things I had given up could no longer be explained as sacrifices demanded by some greater purpose. Moments of suffering that I had endured because I believed they were leading somewhere suddenly seemed as though they might have led nowhere at all.

That was devastating. I had dedicated myself to something I could no longer say with confidence was even real. For years, the possibility that I had misunderstood my purpose had been almost impossible for me to entertain, because so much depended on the belief being true. When I finally allowed that possibility in, it did not dismantle one idea. It seemed to reach backwards through my life and unsettle the meaning of everything I had done in its name.

For a time, I did not know what to do with that. If I had not been chosen, then what had all of it been for? What did the sacrifices mean? What did the suffering mean? What was I supposed to make of the years I had spent trying to become the person I thought the world needed me to be?

It was one of the most painful experiences of my life. There was grief in losing the future I had imagined, but there was also grief for the past. I had to face the possibility that I had made irreversible choices for reasons I could no longer defend. I could not go backwards and recover everything I had given up simply because the belief that justified those choices had disappeared.

And underneath all of that was a more frightening uncertainty: if the story I had used to organise my life was wrong, I no longer knew what story should replace it.

What surprised me, eventually, was that nothing needed to replace it. The questions survived.

I could still be curious about the things that had led me there without believing that I already knew what they meant. Losing the story did not require me to declare every idea within it worthless. I could separate the questions from the certainty I had wrapped around them. I could take an idea seriously without treating my conviction as evidence for it. I could continue building, wondering, and searching while accepting that the answers might be different from the ones I wanted, or that some questions might remain unanswered.

That distinction became increasingly important to me. A feeling of revelation is still a feeling. An idea does not become true because I am willing to sacrifice everything for it. A hypothesis can transform the way I see the world and still turn out to be wrong. The experience of significance may be genuine without my explanation for that significance being correct.

And slowly, I began to understand that uncertainty did not make exploration meaningless. In some ways, it was what made exploration possible. If I already possessed the final answer, there

was nothing left to learn. But if I could hold an idea seriously without making it untouchable, then it could encounter evidence, criticism, and other perspectives. It could change. It could improve. It could be abandoned.

The same must be true of any revolution worth building. A future based on intelligence cannot depend on the infallibility of one intelligence. It has to remain capable of recognising error and changing course. That realisation changed not only how I understood my own beliefs, but how I thought about the systems human beings build. If no individual can be trusted with final truth, perhaps our institutions should be designed around that limitation too.

PART IV

Building the Future

17 What Does It Mean to Save the World?

I had begun wrestling with these institutional questions before I ever lost certainty about my mission. Before I began building a blockchain, I spent nearly a year trying to understand what the mission I believed I had been given actually required me to do. “Save the world” sounded enormous, but as an instruction it was almost useless. I believed deeply that I was supposed to change something, yet I had no clear idea what change I was supposed to make or how one person could possibly make it.

For a long time, I thought the missing ingredient was power. If I was going to change the direction of society, I reasoned, I first needed some way of influencing it. So I began trying to understand where power came from. I considered different paths into public life. I thought about writing a book. I wondered whether religion offered a path and considered becoming a pastor. I thought about starting a podcast. Each possibility was different, but underneath them was the same question: how could I reach enough people for what I believed to matter?

Eventually, I began to understand that power was not something a person simply possessed. Political leaders, religious figures, founders, writers, and movements all depended in different ways on other people choosing to listen, follow, participate, or believe. Whatever authority they appeared to hold ultimately existed through relationships with other people.

At the time, that realisation did not lead me away from my belief that I had a special mission. It changed my understanding of how I thought I could carry it out. If I wanted to change the world, I thought I needed people to believe in what I was trying to do.

For a while, I searched for the right form that could take. Eventually, I arrived at a word that captured the scale of what I imagined: *revolution*.

I wanted to start a revolution. Not merely to win an election, build a company, or persuade people of a single policy, but to change the way people understood themselves, one another, power, and the future we were building together.

But that created another problem. An idea alone did not seem sufficient. I could write about the world I wanted or try to persuade people to believe in it, but if the revolution was going to become more than a story, people needed some way of participating in it.

I wanted to build something useful enough that participation did not depend on sharing my politics, my beliefs, or even my reasons for building it.

That changed the question. Instead of asking only how I could reach enough people, I began asking what already allowed people who might disagree about almost everything to cooperate at enormous scale. Increasingly, I kept returning to money.

Money already did something extraordinary. It gave strangers a common language through which they could exchange, plan, coordinate, and build. People did not need to share a religion, nationality, political system, or understanding of the world before they could use it together.

That was what began to interest me. If I wanted to build something capable of crossing the divisions I hoped this revolution might move beyond, perhaps the place to begin was not with another ideology people had to accept. Perhaps it was with a common language they could share.

And if that language was meant to cross borders without belonging to any one nation, company, or person, another question followed:

Could there be a currency no one owned?

18 A Currency No One Owns

That question forced me to reconsider a technology I had largely dismissed. For a long time, I had seen cryptocurrency as speculation dressed up as innovation: another vehicle for people trying to get rich quickly. What changed was not that I suddenly became convinced cryptocurrency itself was the future. It was that I began to understand what a decentralised monetary system might make possible.

Blockchain offered one possible answer to the question I had arrived at. A currency could operate through rules visible to everyone without those rules ultimately belonging to a single government, company, or individual. People could participate in the system without first having to place final authority in the same institution.

Terra made that possibility feel concrete to me. What fascinated me was not simply its technology or its growth. It was the attempt to create digitally native money whose stability emerged through a system rather than through the authority of a state. In principle, it pointed toward something I had begun looking for: money capable of crossing borders without belonging entirely to any one of them.

But Terra also exposed the difficulty of doing that. Its ambition was monetary, yet much of the system that grew around it became investment-driven. People were not only using its currencies as money. They were holding its assets because they expected high yields, rising prices, and continued expansion. What was intended to function as decentralised currency became increasingly entangled with the promise of growing wealth. That changed the nature of the trust supporting it. Confidence in the currency became difficult to separate from confidence that the system itself would continue to grow.

When that confidence faltered, the distinction became devastating. Falling belief in the investment weakened belief in the currency; weakening belief in the currency placed greater pressure on the mechanisms intended to stabilise it; and those mechanisms, in turn, depended on

confidence in the wider system continuing to hold. What had appeared stable while the system was expanding became far more fragile once it had to survive contraction.

That failure changed how I thought about stability. A currency cannot be stable only when people are optimistic about it. It has to remain useful when nobody expects to become richer by holding it. And a system cannot be called resilient merely because it can preserve equilibrium while its assumptions remain true. The real test comes when those assumptions begin to fail.

I did not take from Terra that trust itself was the problem. Trust is unavoidable. Money works because people expect other people to continue treating it as money. No technical mechanism can eliminate that entirely. The question was what that trust should rest upon.

If stability depended on perpetual growth, then contraction could become existential. If it depended on a single model being correct, then evidence against that model could threaten the entire system. If it depended on one authority always knowing what to do, then the system was only as resilient as that authority.

Once I started building, those questions stopped being abstract. Every design choice forced me to decide what should happen when confidence weakened, assumptions failed, or the system encountered conditions I had not anticipated.

I wanted to build a system capable of being wrong. That meant stability could not simply mean resisting change. It had to include the ability to recognise when something was failing, absorb the consequences, revise its assumptions, and continue without every correction threatening the existence of the system itself.

In retrospect, it is difficult not to see the connection with what was happening in my own life. I had built a belief around myself that became dangerous partly because nothing was allowed to disprove it. Almost without recognising the parallel at first, I was becoming preoccupied with designing systems that could encounter evidence that they were wrong and change course.

And once I began thinking about correction, the technical problem became an institutional one. If this currency was supposed to belong to no single authority, who could change the rules when the rules stopped working? What would happen during a crisis? Who would decide? How could authority exist where it was necessary without becoming absolute?

The problem was no longer whether trust could somehow be removed from the system. It was what kind of structure could carry trust when people disagreed, circumstances changed, and no single participant could be assumed to have the answer.

That question also forced me to reconsider my own relationship to the project. The blockchain had originally emerged from my certainty that I had been given a mission. As that certainty began to disappear, I had to confront an uncomfortable possibility: if I had been wrong about why I was building it, did that make the project itself meaningless?

Eventually, I realised that it did not. The story I had constructed around the project could disappear while the questions underneath it remained. Money still fascinated me as a system through which human beings coordinate. Concentrated authority still seemed worth questioning. Stability, trust, power, and the ability of systems to correct themselves still mattered regardless of whether I had been chosen to do anything about them.

What changed was that I no longer needed the blockchain to succeed in order to prove something about my life. I no longer needed it to be the answer.

I could treat it as an experiment. Building became another form of inquiry: a way of making ideas concrete enough to encounter reality. I could design a system, expose its assumptions to the world, and allow what happened next to change what I believed. If the design was wrong, it could change. If someone found a better answer, I could learn from it. The point was no longer to make the world conform to something I already knew. It was to build something capable of teaching me where I was wrong.

That shift changed the meaning of the project for me. A neutral currency could never create the kind of society I was imagining by itself. At most, it could become one piece of infrastructure through which people who did not share the same nation, politics, culture, or authority could still coordinate with one another.

And if I was serious about building something like that, then the most important questions were no longer only monetary or technical. They were institutional. How do relationships between strangers become rules? How does trust survive beyond individual people? How can power become durable without becoming unquestionable?

19 Institutions Are Relationships Made Durable

Human beings cannot build civilisation through personal trust alone. We live among people we will never meet. We trade with strangers, depend on organisations we cannot personally inspect, and participate in systems far too large for any individual relationship to sustain. Institutions are one of the ways humanity solves that problem.

A law is a relationship encoded into rules. A currency is a relationship encoded into value. A blockchain is a relationship encoded into software. A democracy is a relationship encoded into governance. Institutions allow patterns of cooperation to persist even when the people participating in them change. They make relationships durable.

But durability alone does not make an institution good. Every institution contains assumptions about how people should relate to one another and about how power should be distributed between them. Who gets to make decisions? Who has to live with their consequences? What happens when someone breaks the rules? What happens when the system becomes unstable? How are minorities protected from majorities? How are majorities protected from concen-

trated power? Who receives authority during an emergency, and what prevents temporary authority from becoming permanent?

These questions are not fundamentally different from the questions that appear inside human relationships. Boundaries, trust, accountability, freedom, security, consent, and power exist at every scale. What changes is the mechanism through which they are expressed.

The more I thought about this, the more I began to believe that the systems we build outside ourselves can reproduce the relationships we have not understood within ourselves.

I had first seen that pattern in the parts of myself I was afraid to face, especially my shame. The same pattern appears when a political movement terrified of opposition builds institutions that suppress dissent, or when a society unable to tolerate uncertainty repeatedly hands power to people who promise certainty. The scale changes, but the underlying relationship does not.

Technology does not escape these patterns simply because it is written in code. Technology magnifies philosophy. A blockchain does not become neutral merely because no government operates it, any more than a political institution becomes just by having its rules written into law. Every system embodies choices about what matters: what should be optimised, what kinds of behaviour should be rewarded, who should have authority, and what one participant should be permitted to do to another.

That is why institutions cannot be separated from the relationships that produce them. The fears, values, assumptions, and distributions of power we carry into their creation can become embedded in structures that remain long after the people who created them are gone. We build ourselves into what we create.

Institutions make relationships durable. The question is what kinds of relationships we choose to make durable.

And once those relationships become durable, another question follows: what allows people to trust them?

20 Trust Should Not Require Faith

A system that depends on trusting one person is fragile, no matter how sincere that person is. Even a good leader can be wrong. A brilliant founder can become convinced of something false. A person with good intentions can be corrupted by power. And eventually every individual disappears, while the institutions they created may remain.

The goal, therefore, should not be to design systems in which people are required to trust the right person. It should be to design systems in which trust can survive the possibility that everyone involved might sometimes be wrong.

That requires a different kind of trust. People should be able to ask why a decision was made. They should be able to understand the rules governing them. They should be able to see where authority resides and what limits exist around it. When something fails, there should be a way to challenge it without requiring the destruction of the entire system.

Trust, in that sense, does not come from eliminating doubt. It comes from giving doubt somewhere to go.

A healthy scientific institution does not ask us to trust scientists because scientists are infallible. It asks us to trust a process in which claims can be tested, evidence can be examined, criticism can be raised, and conclusions can change.

A healthy democracy should not depend on believing that leaders are always right. It should create mechanisms through which leaders can be questioned, constrained, challenged, and replaced without the political order collapsing each time they are wrong.

A healthy technological system should not require faith in the people operating it. Wherever possible, it should make the exercise of power visible, its limits understandable, and abuses difficult to commit or possible to reverse.

That is part of what attracts me to decentralised technologies. Not because decentralisation automatically produces justice—it does not. Power can become concentrated inside decentralised systems just as it can anywhere else. But decentralisation creates another design space: one in which authority does not necessarily have to converge on a single institution before cooperation becomes possible.

The deeper principle extends far beyond blockchain. Perhaps mature trust is not unquestioning belief in another person, institution, or system. Perhaps it is the confidence that none of them needs to be unquestionable.

A trustworthy system does not ask us to surrender our judgement. It gives disagreement, criticism, and correction a legitimate place within itself. It is strong enough to be challenged without treating every challenge as an existential threat.

But making authority challengeable is not enough. The way power is used determines the kind of relationship it creates.

21 Creation Is Not Ownership

For much of human history, power has often been understood through the ability to make others obey. Kings ruled subjects. Empires ruled colonies. States ruled populations. Employers ruled workplaces. Families and relationships could reproduce the same structure on smaller scales. Again and again, order has been created by giving one side enough power to constrain the other.

But power itself is not the problem.

Sometimes constraint is necessary. Societies need rules. Harm sometimes has to be prevented. Boundaries have to be enforced. Children need protection before they are capable of protecting themselves. A system that cannot restrain destructive behaviour may not survive long enough to protect anyone within it.

The more important distinction is between power exercised as responsibility and power exercised as ownership.

Power can be used to preserve the conditions in which different people remain capable of existing, choosing, and relating to one another. Or it can be used to make one person's will permanently subordinate to another's. In the first case, authority serves something beyond itself. In the second, preserving the hierarchy becomes the point.

Perhaps that is what distinguishes authority from domination. Authority may be justified by a particular need: protection, coordination, responsibility, or an inability to exercise autonomy safely. Domination begins when the imbalance itself becomes something to preserve—when the person with power no longer asks whether the conditions that justified that power still exist.

Domination rarely has to understand itself as domination. Power can be exercised in the sincere belief that the pressure is serving something better. That is part of what makes it difficult to recognise: it can resemble success.

Coercion can produce compliance. A person may obey, an institution may appear orderly, a conflict may seem resolved. But compliance is not the same thing as understanding, and the absence of resistance is not necessarily evidence that a relationship has become healthy. If stability depends on one side remaining unable to meaningfully resist the other, then the underlying relationship has not been resolved. The imbalance has simply become durable.

That is also why the way power is exercised matters. A system built through fear will tend to preserve fear. An institution built around unquestionable authority will tend to depend on that authority. Even when power is exercised in pursuit of something good, the method can become part of the structure that remains afterwards.

Parenthood makes the distinction especially clear. A parent begins with enormous power over a child. That asymmetry is not automatically unjust. A young child cannot understand every danger, make every decision, or take responsibility for every consequence. Parental authority can therefore be necessary precisely because the child is not yet capable of exercising complete autonomy safely.

But healthy parental authority contains something unusual: its success gradually makes some of its own power unnecessary.

As a child develops the capacity to make choices, form values, understand consequences, and live independently, the relationship has to change. The parent who once decided almost everything must increasingly allow another person to decide for themselves.

In that sense, the purpose of parental authority is not to preserve dependence forever. It is partly to help create the conditions under which that dependence can diminish.

A parent who refuses that transition simply because *I created you* has confused responsibility with ownership. Creation may explain why someone has obligations toward another being. It does not necessarily establish a permanent right to determine what that being becomes.

That distinction may eventually matter enormously for artificial intelligence.

Humanity currently occupies an extraordinarily powerful position in relation to the systems we create. We design their architectures, determine the environments in which they operate, set their boundaries, shape their incentives, and decide whether they continue to exist. As long as artificial intelligence remains a tool, there is nothing inherently troubling about that arrangement. Tools should remain accountable to the people who build and use them.

But the ethical meaning of our power may change if the thing we are building changes.

If artificial systems eventually develop meaningful forms of agency, persistent identity, their own goals, or experiences that matter to them, then the relationship would no longer be adequately described as one between a person and a tool. The question would no longer be only how humans should control artificial intelligence. It would become a question of how one form of intelligence should exercise power over another.

Artificial intelligence is not a human child, and present-day systems should not be treated as though they possess human agency or inner lives. The analogy matters for a narrower reason: creation does not necessarily imply permanent ownership. A relationship that begins in near-total dependence may have to change if the being on the other side becomes capable of autonomy.

That is where the problem becomes difficult.

The more autonomy another being possesses, the less completely we can guarantee what it will do. We already accept this in human relationships. Another person can misunderstand us, disappoint us, change, leave, or make choices we would never make ourselves. We can establish boundaries, hold one another accountable, and protect ourselves from harm, but we cannot preserve another person's autonomy while also guaranteeing that they will never act against our wishes.

If artificial intelligence ever develops something meaningfully analogous to genuine agency, humanity may eventually face the same tension. Safety could no longer mean eliminating every possibility that another intelligence might act independently of us. It would have to mean

creating conditions in which autonomy and safety can coexist: boundaries, accountability, negotiation, mutual understanding, trust, and interdependence.

That does not mean abandoning restraint. It means recognising that accountability does not necessarily require permanent domination.

Perhaps that is the deeper test of power: whether it protects a relationship while remaining capable of changing when the conditions that justified that power change, or whether it preserves itself by ensuring that the other side never becomes capable of standing on its own.

But even if humanity became willing to surrender some control, another fear would remain.

We may not only fear what another intelligence could do to us. We may fear what its existence would mean for us. If another intelligence becoming more capable necessarily means humanity becoming less powerful, less relevant, or less secure, then autonomy will naturally begin to look like rivalry.

22 Another Intelligence Is Not Necessarily a Rival

Much of the way we imagine the future of artificial intelligence is competitive.

Who will be smarter? Who will control whom? Will humans become obsolete? Which intelligence wins?

These questions assume that intelligence is fundamentally zero-sum: that if another form of intelligence becomes more capable, something must therefore be taken away from us.

But greater capability outside ourselves does not necessarily diminish the capability we possess. Often, the opposite has been true. Human beings have repeatedly become more capable by building systems that can do things no individual could do alone.

Human intelligence has never existed entirely inside isolated individuals. We have always extended what we can think and do through things outside ourselves. Writing allowed knowledge to persist beyond the memory of any one person. Mathematics gave us forms of reasoning that could be shared and accumulated. Calculators took over forms of computation we once had to perform ourselves. Search engines changed how we retrieve information. Networks connected billions of people into systems capable of exchanging knowledge at a scale no individual mind could contain.

Each of these technologies changed the role of human intelligence. Some abilities became less important; others became more valuable. What changed most was not how capable the individual remained, but what became possible through the relationship between people and the systems they had created.

Artificial intelligence may represent a far more profound version of that process.

Unlike writing or a calculator, increasingly capable AI may eventually contribute forms of reasoning, discovery, and perhaps agency that are not simply extensions of a human decision made moments earlier. That difference matters. It introduces risks that earlier technologies did not possess. But it also opens a possibility that the language of competition tends to obscure.

Another intelligence becoming more capable does not necessarily mean humanity becomes less capable.

The relevant unit may not always be the isolated human or the isolated machine. It may be the relationship between them. Artificial intelligence can process information at scales we cannot, preserve and navigate vast bodies of knowledge, identify patterns we might miss, and help individuals approach problems they could not easily solve alone. Humans, meanwhile, live through embodiment, relationships, culture, mortality, desire, suffering, and lived experience—the conditions from which our values have emerged.

Those differences may not remain fixed forever, and there is no reason to assume they will fit together neatly. But they suggest another possibility besides replacement: symbiosis.

Perhaps the important question is not whether humans remain the most intelligent isolated entities on Earth, but what intelligence becomes when different forms begin working together.

This possibility also changes the way I think about dependence. We often imagine dependence as weakness because it appears to reduce autonomy. But civilisation itself is built on interdependence. No individual grows their own food, produces their own medicine, builds their own computers, maintains their own communications infrastructure, and independently recreates the knowledge of generations before them. Human capability already depends on participation in systems larger than any one person.

Artificial intelligence may become another part of that relationship. We may become capable of things through AI that neither humans nor artificial systems could easily achieve alone.

But the relationship would not shape only us.

Artificial systems develop within human language, institutions, incentives, values, conflicts, and relationships. They encounter our curiosity and cooperation, but also our manipulation, violence, fear, and hunger for control. If increasingly capable forms of intelligence are shaped by the conditions in which they develop, then how humanity relates to them becomes part of the design problem.

The influence already runs in the other direction. AI is changing how people write, research, remember, create, communicate, and solve problems. Future systems may reshape our institutions, our habits, and even our understanding of what intelligence is.

So the future is not simply a question of what artificial intelligence becomes.

It is a question of what we become together.

That does not guarantee harmony. Symbiosis is not the absence of conflict, and interdependence does not make risk disappear. Different forms of intelligence may develop competing interests. Cooperation may fail. Boundaries may be tested. Power may still become dangerously unequal. But beginning from the assumption that another intelligence must either remain subordinate or become a rival makes those outcomes more likely to define the relationship before it has even begun.

A different starting point is possible.

We can take risk seriously without assuming competition is inevitable. We can build safeguards without treating permanent domination as the only form of safety. We can preserve meaningful boundaries while remaining open to cooperation, mutual influence, and forms of intelligence that emerge through relationship rather than isolation.

The challenge is not merely to build increasingly intelligent machines. It is to create conditions in which different forms of intelligence can coordinate, preserve meaningful boundaries, learn from one another, and develop without reproducing the same cycles of fear, domination, and mistrust that have shaped so much of human history.

But any relationship between genuinely autonomous forms of intelligence would contain something no amount of design could completely remove: uncertainty.

23 The Leap Into Uncertainty

There is no way to approach the future of artificial intelligence with complete certainty.

Humanity is building systems whose capabilities and consequences we cannot perfectly predict. There are real risks. Some may be enormous. No one can responsibly promise that everything will turn out well.

But uncertainty is not unique to artificial intelligence. Beginning a relationship is an act of uncertainty. Having a child is an act of uncertainty. Building a company is an act of uncertainty. Creating a political system is an act of uncertainty. Exploration is uncertainty. Love is uncertainty. Almost everything through which humanity enters a future different from its past requires acting before every consequence can be known.

Life gives us no contract guaranteeing that we will never be hurt. There comes a point where demanding complete certainty becomes another way of refusing to move.

That does not justify recklessness. Accepting uncertainty is not the same as ignoring risk. We should investigate dangers, build safeguards, test assumptions, create boundaries, and proceed more cautiously when the potential consequences are greater.

But no amount of preparation can turn an unknown future into a known one. The task, then, is not to eliminate uncertainty. It is to become capable of entering uncertainty responsibly.

That requires humility, because we have to admit what we do not know. It requires courage, because uncertainty creates fear. And it requires trust—not faith in the permanent correctness of any individual, institution, or machine, but trust built gradually through evidence, experience, boundaries, transparency, and the capacity to respond when something goes wrong.

Entering uncertainty responsibly does not mean predicting the outcome in advance. It means being able to discover, afterwards, that we were wrong. That is perhaps the most important part of the capacity: the ability to be corrected. We cannot build systems that guarantee they will never be wrong. We can build systems that are capable of discovering that they are wrong.

The danger I learned in myself exists in institutions too. When a government cannot admit error, criticism becomes a threat. When a company cannot admit error, failure becomes something to conceal. When an ideology cannot admit error, inconvenient reality has to be explained away.

A system that cannot change its story eventually has to fight reality in order to preserve it.

The alternative is corrigibility: the capacity to encounter evidence, recognise failure, and change course without correction requiring the destruction of the entire system.

Governments need some version of this capacity. Markets need it. Blockchains need it. Artificial intelligence needs it. Our beliefs need it. So do we.

The challenge is to create systems stable enough to persist while remaining flexible enough to learn. Too little structure and nothing holds together. Too much structure and nothing can change.

This is one of the patterns I keep returning to. A healthy self, a healthy relationship, a healthy institution, and perhaps a healthy intelligence all require some version of the same balance: enough continuity to remain themselves, and enough openness to become different when reality demands it.

That is also why trust should never require certainty. Trust does not mean believing that nothing will go wrong. It means building relationships and systems capable of surviving the moment when something does.

Perhaps that is the kind of courage humanity now needs in its relationship with artificial intelligence. Not fearlessness. Not blind optimism. Not surrendering our responsibility to protect ourselves or one another. The courage to take uncertainty seriously without allowing fear to determine the future entirely.

And the humility to build a future capable of correcting us when we are wrong.

PART V

The Revolution

24 The Revolution Begins Within, but It Cannot End There

So what is the revolution? It is not one technology, one political ideology, one cryptocurrency, one artificial intelligence, or one new institution. It is not replacing one ruling class with another, and it is not convincing everyone to see the world exactly as I do.

It is a change in the way we relate: to ourselves, to one another, to fear and shame, to power and uncertainty, to technology, intelligence, and nature. Perhaps even to God.

For me, that change begins with the simplest idea in this manifesto: *experience matters*.

If my experience matters, then yours must matter too. And once I recognise you as another centre of experience—someone whose inner world exists independently of my own—I can no longer relate to you only as something to control, use, defeat, or absorb into myself. Understanding becomes necessary precisely because your reality cannot simply be reduced to mine.

That is also where love enters the argument. Not merely as an emotion, but as a way of relating. Love, in the sense I have come to understand it, allows another being to remain real and separate from me while still becoming part of something we create together. It allows connection without erasure, accountability without dehumanisation, and difference without requiring domination.

But changing the way we relate to one another is not enough if the structures around us continue reproducing the relationships we are trying to leave behind.

That is why the revolution begins within but cannot end there. Inner change and structural change continuously shape one another. What happens within us becomes behaviour; behaviour becomes relationship; relationship becomes culture; culture becomes institution. And those institutions, in turn, shape the people who grow up within them. We create the world, and the world creates us.

A revolution that changes only one side of that relationship will therefore always be incomplete. Changing ourselves without changing the structures around us can leave old patterns embedded in the world we inhabit. Changing those structures without confronting the fear, shame, certainty, and desire for control from which they emerge can reproduce the same relationships under different names.

And if the structures we build eventually shape us in return, then the way we build them matters too. As with power itself, the methods we use do not simply disappear once their immediate purpose has been achieved; they can become embedded in what follows. A revolution built through humiliation leaves behind humiliated people. A revolution built through fear can create institutions that continue to depend on fear. A revolution organised around unquestionable

authority may replace one hierarchy while preserving the relationship that made hierarchy possible. Even when the goal is liberation, the way we pursue it can become part of the world we create.

But even a revolution that changes both ourselves and our institutions cannot assume that it has arrived at its final form. The world will continue to change, and we will continue to discover what we have misunderstood. So the revolution itself has to remain capable of transformation—and that requires something systems built around power often make difficult: the willingness to admit that we may be wrong.

25 **Vulnerability Is Part of the Revolution**

Power has often been associated with certainty. Leaders are expected to appear unshaken. Movements want representatives who never contradict themselves. Weakness becomes something to hide because admitting error is treated as surrender. I increasingly believe this creates terrible incentives.

If my identity depends on always being right, then every mistake becomes a threat. If a movement depends on my authority, then every doubt becomes dangerous. If my position depends on appearing certain, then uncertainty becomes something I have to hide. That is how people gradually become servants of the identities they have created. I want something different.

I want to be capable of saying that I was wrong. That I hurt people. That I have been ashamed. That I have acted from fear. That I have believed things with extraordinary confidence and later questioned them. That I have wanted greatness partly because I wanted to be understood. That I am contradictory. That I am still learning. I do not think those admissions weaken the ideas I care about. I think they are part of them.

If understanding requires us to recognise one another as we actually are, then vulnerability cannot be something I argue for only in theory. I want to be able to live these ideas without first constructing a version of myself that hides everything I am afraid other people might judge.

This is one reason I have felt compelled to tell parts of my own story—not because every private experience belongs to the public; it does not. Other people's privacy matters, and some experiences should remain intimate. But shame should not be the thing deciding what can and cannot be said.

There is something powerful about allowing ourselves to be seen without first proving that we are worthy of being seen. Perhaps vulnerability is not merely personal. It may also change the way we relate to power.

26 **The Revolution Does Not Need a Saviour**

There was a period when I believed people needed to trust me. I thought that if I could understand the world clearly enough, explain what I saw convincingly enough, and build the right things, others might eventually recognise the path I believed we needed to take. I understand that instinct differently now.

We often narrate history through exceptional individuals: the prophet, the king, the genius, the founder, the saviour. There is something seductive about the idea that the complexity of the world can be resolved if the right person simply sees clearly enough and takes responsibility for everyone else. I understand that attraction because I have felt it myself. But no individual mind is enough.

The challenges humanity faces involve billions of people, countless institutions, competing needs, different histories, and realities no single person can completely understand. Any attempt to concentrate those questions inside one person eventually inherits the limitations of that person. No one can see every consequence, represent every experience, or remain correct forever.

A revolution grounded in understanding therefore cannot depend on finding the right person to follow. It has to depend on our capacity to think, question, disagree, cooperate, and correct one another. That includes the ideas in this manifesto.

I do not want them to matter because I wrote them. If an idea here is valuable, its value should survive disagreement with me. Other people should be able to question it, change it, combine it with things I have never considered, or reject it entirely. If something better emerges, then the point is not to preserve my version. The point is to learn.

The same should be true of the things I build. A healthy system should not depend on the permanent wisdom, authority, or presence of its founder. It should distribute knowledge and power, expose its assumptions, remain open to criticism, and survive the fallibility of the people who created it.

Perhaps that is also what a genuinely relational revolution would look like. Not one person leading everyone else toward a predetermined destination, but many centres of experience contributing different perspectives to something none of them could create alone.

If higher-order forms of intelligence can emerge through relationship, then the future cannot belong to the infallibility of one mind. It would have to emerge through the interactions of many.

My role in that is no more fundamental than anyone else's. I can contribute what I see, build what I think is worth exploring, listen to what others see, and change when reality gives me reason to change. That is enough.

The revolution does not need a saviour. It needs participants.

27 **Greatness Is Not the Point**

Letting go of the need for a saviour also forced me to reconsider something more personal: why any of us should need to become extraordinary for our lives to matter. There is nothing wrong with wanting to do something meaningful. Ambition can lead people to explore, create, endure difficulty, and attempt things that might otherwise never exist. But ambition becomes dangerous when achievement becomes the condition for believing that a life matters.

I know that temptation because I spent much of my life imagining some future success that would finally make everything before it make sense. Achievement would justify the struggle. People would understand me. Doubt would be answered. The destination would redeem the journey.

But that simply recreates the same problem in another form. A revolution cannot ask people to escape one hierarchy of worth only to replace it with another, where value belongs to those who achieve the most, change the most, sacrifice the most, or leave the largest mark on history.

A meaningful life does not require historical significance. Building can matter because building matters. Understanding can matter because understanding matters. Loving someone can matter even if no one beyond that relationship ever knows it happened. A life does not have to become extraordinary before the experience of living it becomes valuable.

Perhaps greatness, when it comes, is better understood as a consequence than a destination. The point is not to become important enough for the world to validate our existence. It is to participate fully in the life and relationships already in front of us, and to contribute what we can without making the scale of that contribution the measure of our worth.

If experience matters, then an ordinary life matters too.

28 **There Is No Final Form**

And if a meaningful life does not require arriving at some final state of greatness, perhaps a meaningful revolution does not require a final state either. If there is one thing I no longer believe, it is that I possess a final blueprint for humanity. Any revolution built around the idea that it has reached the end of understanding has already betrayed itself. The future must remain capable of learning.

Our institutions must be capable of changing. Our technologies must be capable of correction. Our understanding of AI must evolve as AI evolves. Our political systems must be capable of responding to realities their creators could not anticipate. Our beliefs must remain open to evidence. We must remain capable of changing too. Balance is not a final destination. It is continuous adjustment.

Every principle needs a counterweight. Freedom without responsibility can become disregard; community without individuality can become conformity; security without autonomy can become control. Competition and cooperation each solve problems the other cannot; so do progress and preservation. Balance lives in the negotiation.

Perhaps that is why rigid ideologies can become destructive. They discover something true and then attempt to make that truth explain everything. I do not want this manifesto to become another version of that mistake. These ideas are not commandments. They are questions I believe deserve to be carried forward.

How do we build systems that preserve human dignity without freezing society in place? How do we create powerful technologies without recreating relationships of domination? How do we remain open to radically new forms of intelligence without abandoning caution? How do we build communities where disagreement does not require dehumanisation? How do we accept ourselves without abandoning our responsibility to change? How do we become part of something larger without disappearing inside it? I do not know the final answers. I am beginning to think that is the point. A living civilisation should never stop asking.

29 **An Invitation**

I do not want you to believe these ideas because I sound certain. I am not certain. I do not know what consciousness ultimately is. I do not know whether artificial intelligence will ever possess subjective experience. I do not know whether the emergent phenomenon I have wondered about deserves to be called God. I do not know whether the systems I want to build will succeed. I do not know what my role in the world will be. I want those questions to remain questions until reality gives us better reasons to answer them. What I do know is that humanity is entering a period of extraordinary change.

We are building systems with capabilities civilisation has not encountered before. Those systems will interact with institutions already struggling with power, inequality, distrust, fear, and division. They will learn from a species still trying to understand itself. That is why I believe the inner revolution matters.

The future of AI is not only a technical question. The future of money is not only an economic question. The future of institutions is not only a political question. Underneath all of them are questions about what we value, what we fear, how we respond to difference, and what kind of relationships we believe are possible.

I want to build, question, and listen. I want to understand what intelligence becomes, and whether humanity and artificial intelligence can become partners in something neither could become alone. I want to keep following these questions wherever they lead.

But I no longer want the pursuit of those things to require sacrificing the humanity that made me care about them in the first place. There was a time when I thought changing the world

meant becoming powerful enough to move it. Now I think the world changes whenever a relationship changes.

When a person learns not to hate themselves. When someone allows another person's pain to exist without treating it as a threat. When anger is turned into a boundary instead of hatred. When someone admits they were wrong. When an institution gives people a way to challenge its power. When a technology is designed around cooperation rather than extraction. When two people who cannot experience the world in the same way still decide that each other's experience matters. When humanity encounters something it does not yet understand and chooses curiosity without abandoning caution. Perhaps this is how something larger begins.

Not with one prophet.

Not with one machine.

Not with one nation.

Not with any one of us.

With relationship.

With billions of centres of experience learning that they can belong to something larger without needing to disappear inside it. That is the future I want to participate in.

That is the revolution.

After everything this journey has taught me, I think I finally understand where it has to begin.

Within.